

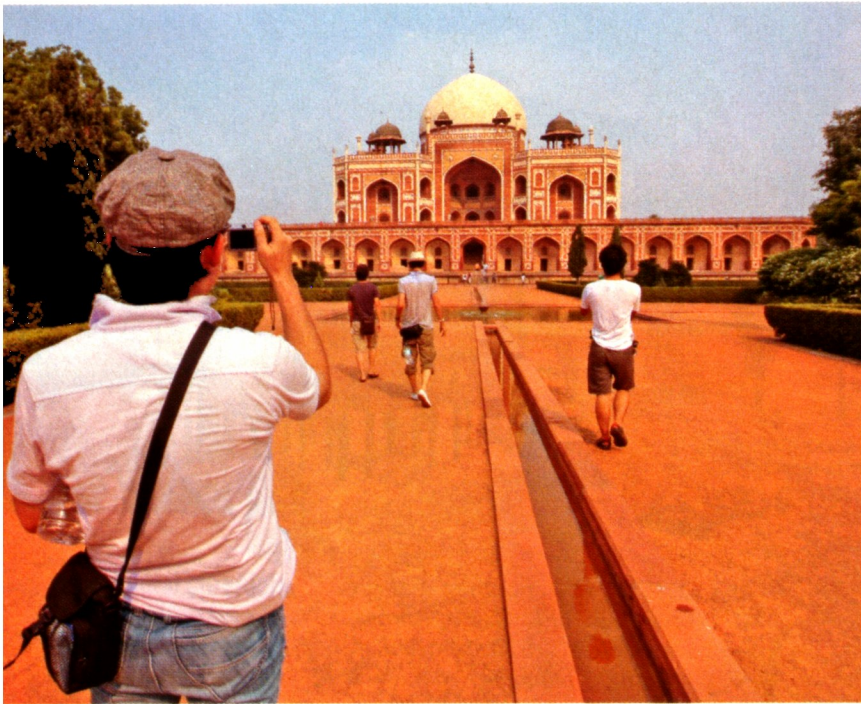
GREAT IDEAS



GREAT MINDS

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There's more to heritage than tacky samosas and rickety tea stalls. It needs to be **PACKAGED WITH PANACHE.**



RAVI S. SAHANI

Capturing history:
The Humayun's Tomb complex underwent a substantial renovation with private help

As a student of architectural conservation, I once presented a design concept of introducing a fine dining restaurant at Arab ki Serai near Humayun's Tomb and watched horrified as the faculty nearly choked on the blasphemous idea. A few years later, when I trained at the 11th century Lincoln Cathedral in England, I was treated to lunch at a café in the medieval cloisters and invited to a wedding in a 15th century castle. The jet-setting crowd who are now willing to pay a minor fortune for the experience can host a private cocktail party at the tower of the historic London Bridge. While Indian museums offer nothing better than tacky samosas and most do not even have a canteen, one of the major revenue earners for

New York's Metropolitan Museum and London's V&A, are the elegant fine dining restaurants. The Asian Art Museum in San Francisco is often the venue for high-profile wine evenings and the 2008 London Fashion Week was recently held at the Victorian Neo-Gothic Museum of Natural History.

In the absence of conservation management plans and constructive dialogue with local municipal bodies, we have cases such as Mehrauli, where jazzy concrete buildings rub shoulders with Zafar Mahal, the last Mughal emperor's palace, and a public urinal built a few metres away from a sultanate period tomb in Jaunpur. While the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and local authorities play the blame game in Mumbai, slums envelop the ancient cave sites, with toilets virtually draining into the rock face.

And yet, it would be considered blasphemous in the Indian scenario if any one merely suggested having a café and museum shop located within any historic monument, and most of the custodians of our culture would balk at the thought of adaptive reuse of even secular structures such as Rajon ki Baoli, Arab ki Serai, Fatehpur Sikri, Jahaz Mahal, Mandu or Hampi Bazaar for occasional crafts exhibitions and festivals.

The UK, like most European countries, sees heritage as a major asset and packages its historical sites with unrivalled panache. In 2005-06, the public funding of English Heritage, officially known as the Historic Buildings and Monuments Commission, raised £170 million through a combination of ticket sales, museum shops, events and public patronage. In 2002, post the trauma of 9/11, the Philadelphia Museum of Art raised a staggering \$42.4 million, probably larger than the entire Indian budget for cultural institutions. Moving away from an archaeology-dominated system, English Heritage and National Trust, UK, have a multi disciplinary